U.S. Flight Performance: Pre- vs Post-COVID

49.3M scheduled flights · Jan 2019 – Jun 2026 · Source: U.S. Bureau of Transportation Statistics

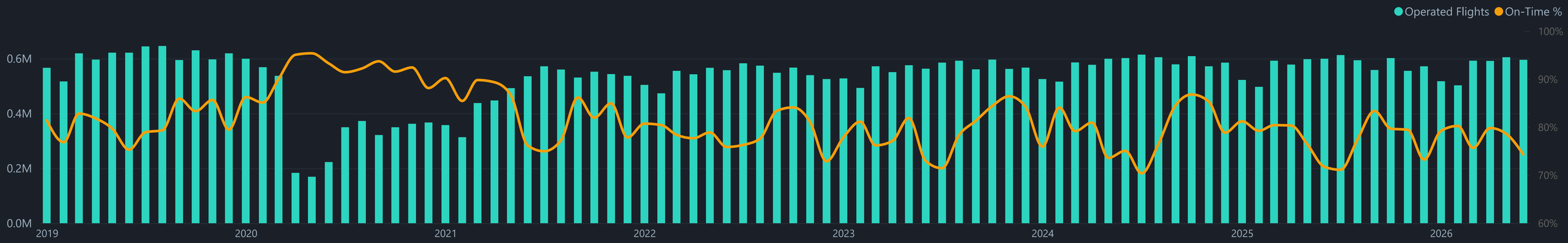
Overview | Recovery | Reliability | Airports | Explore

2025

Flights operated	On-time arrivals	Flights cancelled	Avg delay when late (min)	Volume vs 2019
6.88M	77.7%	1.5%	77.4	-5.3%

In 2025, airlines operated 6,879,485 flights - 5.3% below 2019 and 1.2% down on the prior year. 77.7% arrived on time: 3.2 points worse than 2019, 1.5 points worse than 2024.

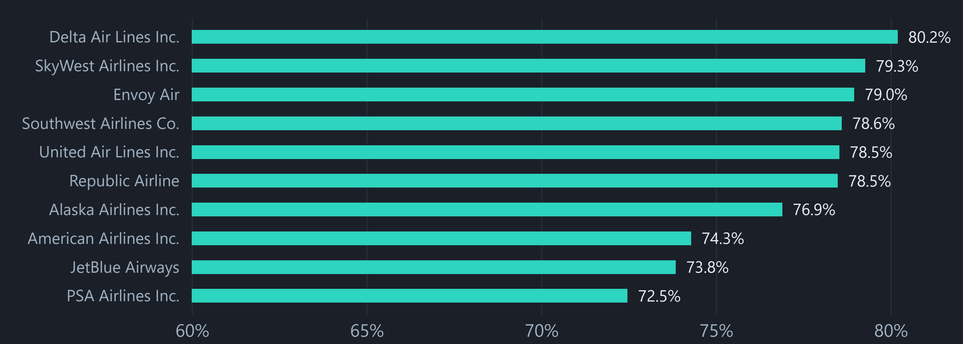
Flight volume vs on-time performance, monthly



Performance by period

Period	Flights	On-time	Cancelled	Avg delay (min)
Pre-COVID	8,435,576	81.6%	1.7%	73.9
Disruption	9,110,452	86.0%	3.9%	70.9
Recovery	13,275,417	79.2%	2.0%	73.2
Post-COVID	17,247,353	78.3%	1.6%	76.8
All periods	**48,068,798**	**80.6%**	**2.2%**	**74.5**

On-time % - 10 largest airlines by volume



What the data shows

Volume has effectively recovered. The 12 airlines reporting throughout the period now fly more than they did in 2019, and the apparent shortfall in totals comes largely from carriers leaving BTS reporting.

Reliability has not. On-time arrivals fell from 81.6% before COVID to 78.3% post-COVID, and 2025 was the weakest full year at 77.7%.

2020 was the most punctual year on record at 90.2%, because near-empty skies removed congestion, not because airlines improved.

** Analysis excludes cancelled and diverted flights from on-time calculations.*

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Volume recovery vs 2019 baseline · like-for-like airline comparison

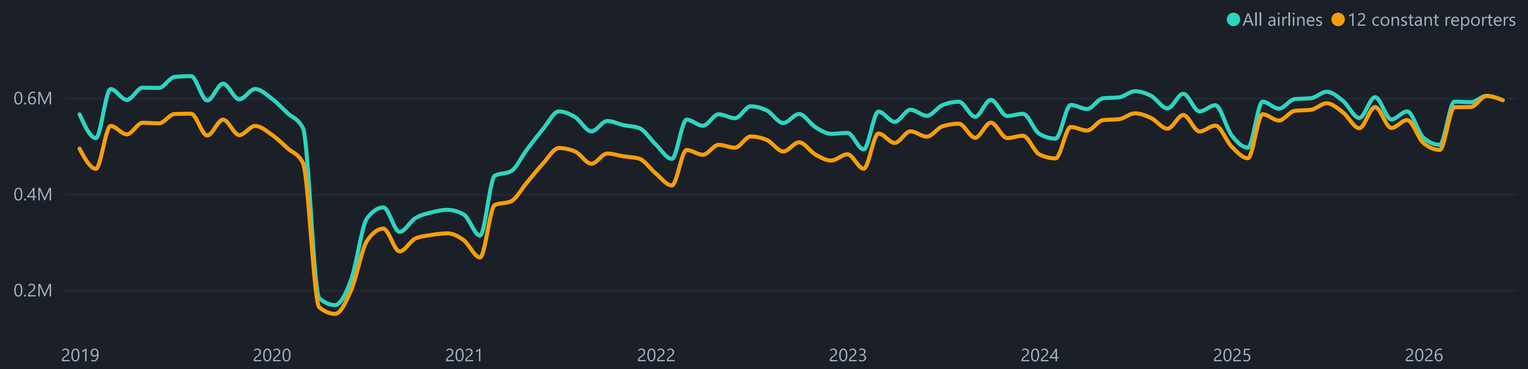
Overview | **Recovery** | Reliability | Airports | Explore

2025

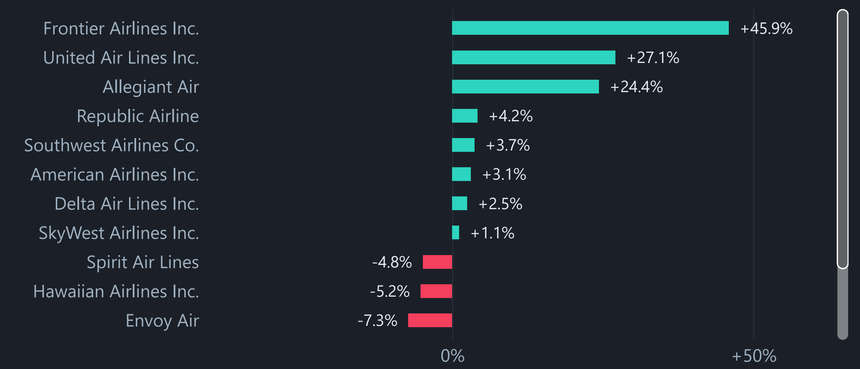
Flights operated	vs 2019 (all airlines)	Flights — 12 constant reporters	Year over year
6.88M	-5.3%	6.61M	-1.2%

Across all carriers, 2025 volume was 5.3% below 2019. The 12 airlines reporting in every month flew 6,608,959 of those flights (96.1% of the total).

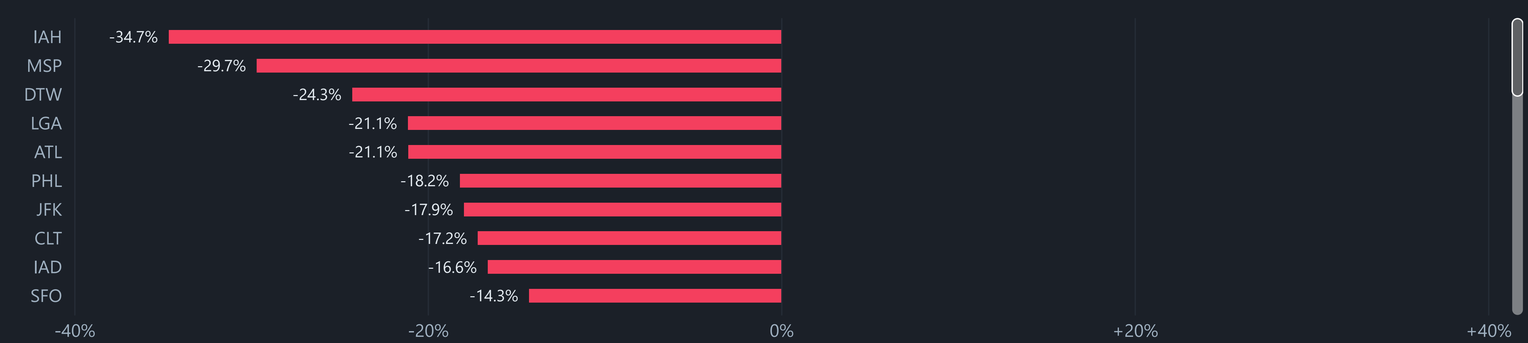
All airlines vs the 12 constant reporters



Recovery vs 2019, by airline



Recovery vs 2019, by airport (50k+ flights)



Recovery is uneven

The headline number understates recovery. All airlines are 5.3% below 2019, but the 12 carriers that report throughout are only 1.2% down year over year, and several fly more than they did before the pandemic.

Airlines diverged sharply. Frontier grew 45.9% against 2019 while JetBlue fell 22.6%, so the network was reshaped rather than restored.

Coverage changes matter. Six carriers left BTS reporting during the period, which alone accounts for part of the apparent decline in totals.

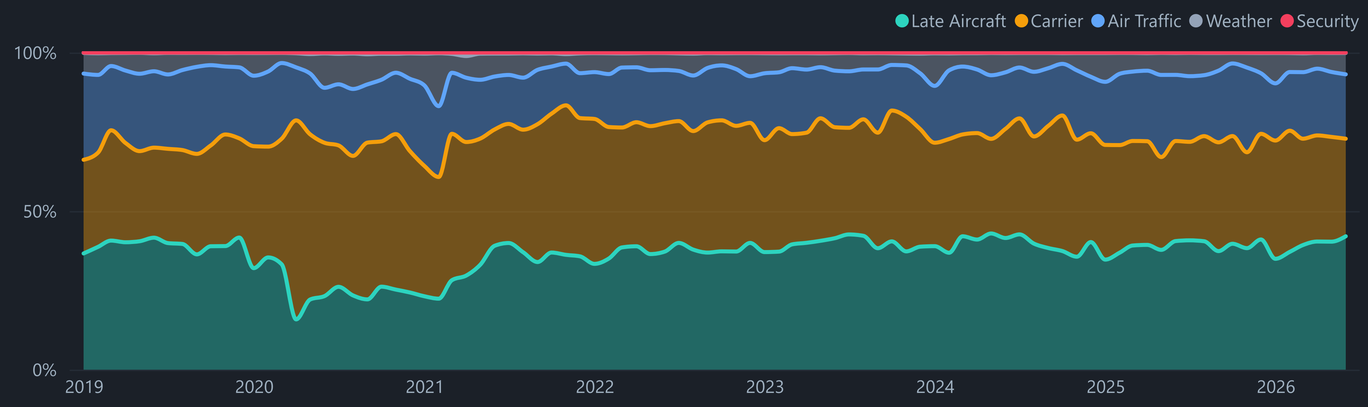
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On-time performance, delay causes, and schedule padding

On-time arrivals	vs 2019	Avg delay, all flights (min)	Avg delay when late (min)	Schedule padding (min)
77.7%	-3.2	8.5	77.4	7.5

77.7% of 2025 flights arrived on time, 3.2 points worse than 2019. Late flights ran 77 minutes behind on average, most often because of late-arriving aircraft.

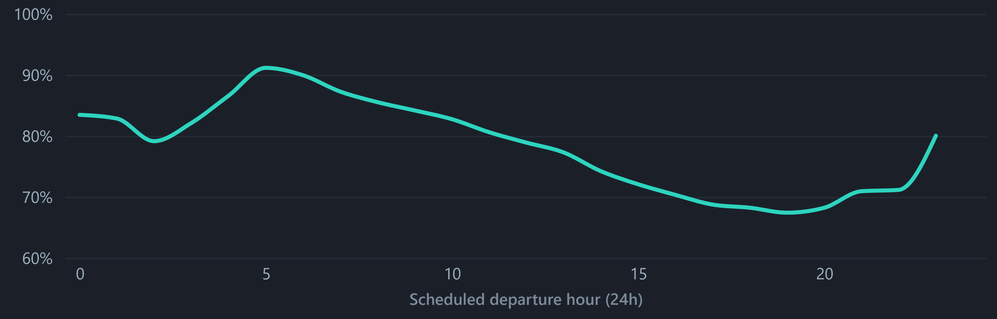
What causes delays, share of total delay minutes



On-time % by weekday and month

Day	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Monday	77.4%	79.2%	76.8%	81.6%	72.2%	73.6%	68.7%	77.5%	83.9%	74.6%	76.6%	72.6%
Tuesday	84.7%	83.9%	86.9%	86.4%	77.9%	74.4%	73.0%	83.5%	87.5%	83.0%	83.9%	76.7%
Wednesday	86.7%	79.5%	83.7%	80.4%	79.5%	73.0%	72.3%	80.3%	85.4%	85.4%	85.2%	78.9%
Thursday	82.6%	71.5%	82.8%	75.6%	77.0%	69.1%	69.0%	76.7%	78.8%	79.9%	81.2%	77.0%
Friday	80.5%	82.4%	80.8%	75.5%	74.1%	69.4%	72.6%	74.7%	81.1%	79.4%	81.9%	69.3%
Saturday	78.4%	81.5%	81.2%	81.7%	81.0%	74.4%	74.7%	77.1%	84.8%	81.6%	79.0%	73.1%
Sunday	77.4%	77.6%	73.8%	80.3%	73.5%	69.0%	68.0%	74.7%	82.1%	74.0%	71.3%	64.0%

On-time % by scheduled departure hour



Delay causes and schedule padding by period

Period	Late Aircraft	Carrier	Air Traffic	Weather	Padding (min)
Pre-COVID	36.4%	29.0%	22.2%	5.2%	8.3
Disruption	30.5%	38.0%	15.9%	6.4%	12.4
Recovery	36.2%	35.5%	16.3%	5.0%	8.8
Post-COVID	37.3%	31.6%	19.1%	5.9%	8.2
All periods	**36.0%**	**33.1%**	**18.4%**	**5.6%**	**9.2**

Reliability Findings

Not a scheduling trick. Padding is 8.2 minutes post-COVID versus 8.3 pre-COVID, so weaker punctuality is a real operational decline.

Delays cascade through the day. On-time runs near 90% at 6am and falls to about 67% by early evening.

Weather is minor. It accounts for only 5.6% of delay minutes. Late aircraft and carrier operations account for 69%.

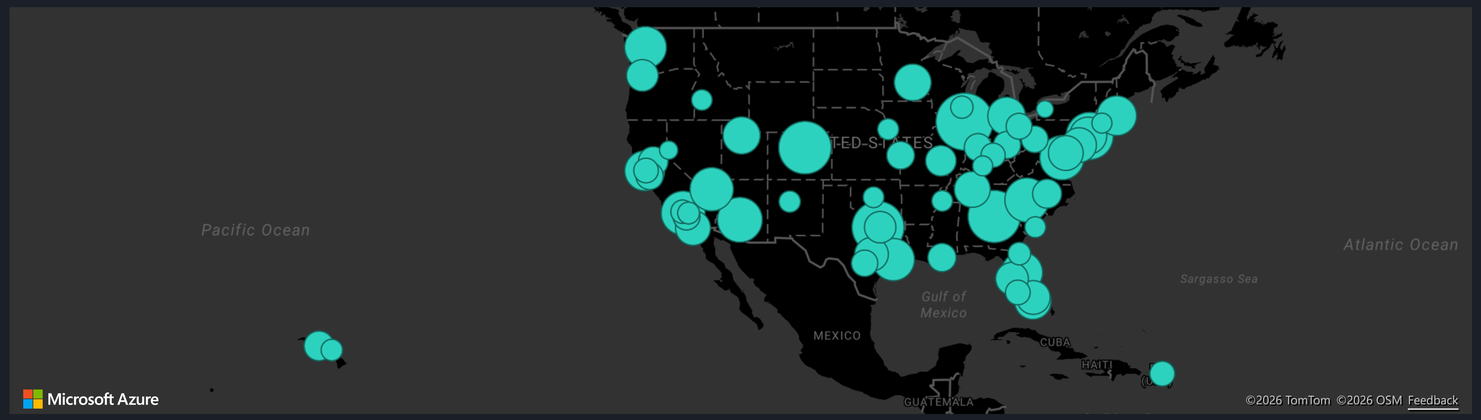
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Airport performance, congestion, and route analysis

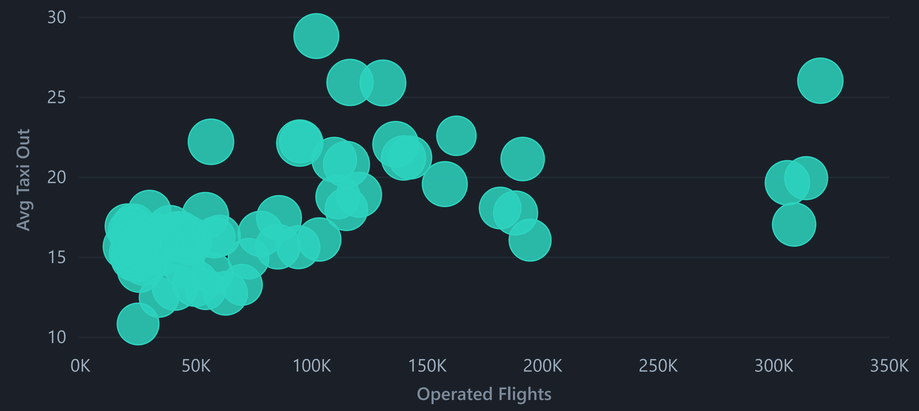
Departures	Avg taxi out (min)	On-time arrivals	Diverted
6.88M	18.6	77.7%	0.3%

Departures in 2025 covered 352 airports. Aircraft spent 18.6 minutes taxiing out on average before takeoff.

Departure volume by airport



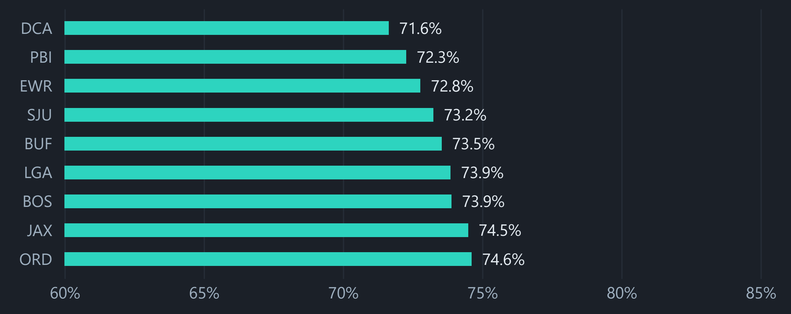
Airport congestion: volume vs taxi-out time



Airport performance (20k+ departures)

Airport	Departures	On-time	Taxi out (min)	Diverted
ORD - Chicago, IL	320,418	73.5%	26.0	0.3%
DEN - Denver, CO	314,281	74.3%	19.9	0.3%
ATL - Atlanta, GA	309,064	76.0%	17.0	0.3%
DFW - Dallas/Fort Worth, TX	306,185	71.3%	19.6	0.3%
PHX - Phoenix, AZ	194,840	80.4%	16.0	0.3%
CLT - Charlotte, NC	191,629	75.3%	21.1	0.2%

Worst airports to arrive into



Airport Findings

Congestion isn't just volume. Chicago O'Hare averages 26 minutes of taxi-out time against Phoenix's 16, on comparable traffic. Layout and capacity matter more than flight count alone.

Traffic shifted from legacy hubs to Sun Belt cities. Austin, Nashville and Denver grew over 27% against 2019, while Houston, Minneapolis and Detroit fell more than 24%.

Arrival airports differ sharply. Reagan National is the hardest to arrive into at 71.6% on time, against 85%+ at the best performers.

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Interactive drill-down into delay drivers

Where delay minutes come from

Period × Post-COVID

Airline ×



How to use this page

The tree starts with total arrival delay minutes and lets you break them down however you choose. Click the **+** on any node to split by period, year, airline, airport, departure hour, month or weekday.

The **High value** and **Low value** options let Power BI pick the split that explains the most variation, which often surfaces patterns a fixed chart would miss.

Worth trying: split by airline, then by departure hour, to see which carriers' delays concentrate late in the day.

What drives on-time performance

Key influencers | Top segments

What influences On-Time % to Increase ?

